

Part One: Reading Comprehension (Score: 12)

*Read the following text in which the writer sheds light on the health issues faced by **Lizzie Velasquez** and how these challenges influenced different aspects of her life. When you are through with the reading, answer the questions that follow.*

When Courage Speaks Louder Than Cruelty

1. What defines a person's value: outward appearance or inner strength? Why do people often judge others before trying to understand them? For Lizzie Velasquez, these questions were not an abstract idea but a reality she faced from the very beginning of her life. Born into a world quick to judge and slow to understand, Lizzie's journey became one of resilience, courage, and the quiet determination to define herself on her own terms.
2. From the moment she was born in 1989, in Austin, Texas, Lizzie stood apart. She arrived four weeks **prematurely**, weighing less than one kilogram, so small and fragile that doctors immediately feared for her future. Shortly after her birth, specialists identified an extremely rare genetic disorder known as lipodystrophy syndrome. It is a condition that prevents the body from storing fat and gaining weight. For Lizzie, however, the diagnosis came with heavy predictions. Doctors warned her parents that their daughter might never walk, speak clearly, or live independently.
3. As Lizzie grew, she remained unusually thin due to her condition, and over time she developed severe vision problems that affected her daily life. She eventually lost sight in one eye and **retained** only limited vision in the other, making simple tasks more difficult. These physical limitations added to her medical struggles and reinforced the challenges she faced. She was trying to navigate a world not designed for someone with her condition.
4. The world outside her home, however, was less forgiving. When Lizzie began school, she quickly learned that being different often attracted cruelty rather than understanding. Persistent stares followed her through hallways, and harsh comments lingered behind her wherever she went. Ordinary school days became emotionally exhausting, as she was constantly reminded that she did not fit in. Over time, the merciless bullying wore her down, increasing her sense of isolation and leaving her feeling deeply misunderstood and alone.
5. The most painful moment of Lizzie's life arrived during her teenage years, carried by the cold reach of the internet. In her early teens, she discovered a video of herself posted online under the cruel title "*The World's Ugliest Woman*." Within a short time, it attracted millions of views and thousands of comments. One of the top comments was "EWWW WHAT A MONSTER!!!". The words were sharp and merciless, attacking her appearance and even questioning her right to exist. For a young girl still learning who she was, **the experience** was deeply **shattering**. It was a moment that could have silenced her forever.
6. Instead, it became the moment that changed everything. After tears and self-doubt, Lizzie made a decision that would define her future. She refused to allow cruelty to shape her identity. Rather than hiding, she chose to speak. Rather than surrendering to hatred, she chose purpose. Slowly, she began to understand that her voice could become a shield—not only for herself, but for countless others who suffered in silence.
7. Determined to strengthen that voice, Lizzie pursued her studies at Texas State University, where she majored in communication. Education gave her the tools to transform personal pain into meaningful expression. Her story, once deeply personal, soon began to resonate far beyond her own life.

8. In 2013, Lizzie delivered a TEDx talk titled “*How Do You Define Yourself?*” The talk spread rapidly on social media platform and reached millions of viewers around the world. Calm yet powerful, her message challenged audiences to reject harmful labels and measure worth through character rather than appearance. For many, it was the first time they reconsidered how easily judgment is formed. Her message soon extended beyond academic platforms to international television, including an appearance on *The Dr. Oz Show*. Dr. Oz highlighted her story, which appeared in several podcasts, as a powerful example of resilience and self-acceptance.

9. Today, Lizzie Velasquez is an international advocate against bullying and discrimination, using her experiences to promote empathy and self-acceptance. Her journey shows that a person’s value is defined by character rather than appearance, encouraging individuals to reflect on their behaviors and reject cruelty while respecting differences in others.

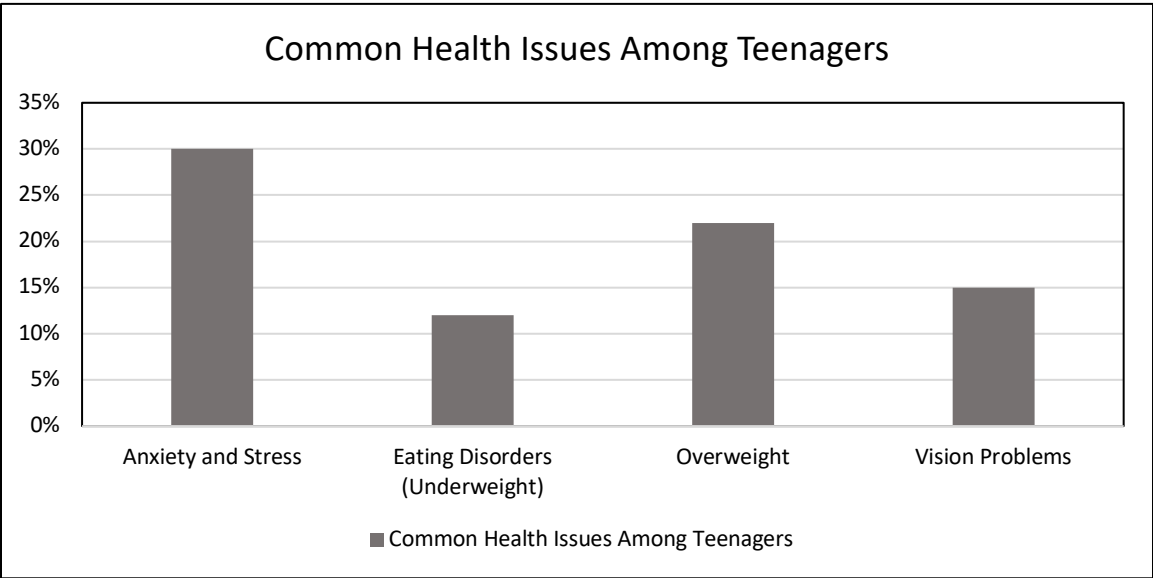
A. Answer each of the following questions in 1-3 complete sentences of your own.

1. Identify the genetic disorder Lizzie Velasquez suffers from, and then mention **two** medical consequences of this condition. (Score: 01)
2. How was school an emotionally exhausting environment for Lizzie? Give two details. (Score: 01)
3. Based on Paragraphs 5 and 8, explain how social media played **both a positive and a negative role** in shaping Lizzie Velasquez’s personal journey. (Score: 1.5)
4. The writer asks, “*What defines a person’s value: outward appearance or inner strength?*” Elaborate how Lizzie Velasquez’s life answers this question. Provide examples from the text. (Score: 1.5)

B. Answer each of the following questions in complete sentences.

1. Identify two purposes the introduction serves. Explain the functions of these two purposes. (Score: 1.5)
2. What is the thematic relationship between Paragraphs 5 and 6? Justify your answer. (Score: 1.5)
3. The above text is a biographical narrative. Explain why, and then state the writer’s purpose. (Score: 01)

C. The bar graph below shows the percentages of some common health issues among teenagers in the year 2024. (Score: 1.5)



What can you conclude about teenagers’ health based on the bar graph? Support your answers with evidence.

D. What does each of the following words, bold-typed and underlined in the selection above, refer to?

(Score: 0.5)

1. The experience (Paragraph 5)
2. They (Paragraph 8)

E. Use contextual clues to figure out the meaning of each word in the box below. Then, fill in the blanks with the correct words to complete the following sentences. (Score: 01)

prematurely (Paragraph 2)	retained (paragraph 3)	shattering (Paragraph 5)
resilience (Paragraph 8)	advocate (Paragraph 9)	

1. She became an active _____ for children with disabilities. She spoke up in meetings and wrote articles to help them find jobs in society.
2. Because of the harsh car accident, he only _____ a very weak memory of the event. He was still confused and unsettled.
3. The news of her deformed image was a _____ incident that left her numb and unable to speak for days.
4. The family's son was born with a mental disability, but they showed great _____ and determination to teach their kid skills that would help him live independently and confidently.

Part Two: Writing (Score: 08)

Choose ONE of the following prompts.

Prompt (A):

"Society's pressure to be thin can influence the way people see themselves and how they live their daily lives."

In a well-organized cause-effect essay, discuss TWO negative effects of the obsession with outer appearance on an individual's physical and emotional well-being. Explain how society's pressure to be good looking can lower self-esteem, contribute to eating disorders, harm mental health, or damage social relationships. Support your discussion with clear explanations, relevant details, and examples.

Prompt (B):

"Sometimes, overcoming the pressure to fit in teaches us to value our true selves."

In a well-organized biographical narrative essay, write about a person who suffered from a disability (whether physical or mental) and show this challenge affected him/her. Describe the situation, the person's thoughts and feelings, and the challenges that resulted from this experience. Reflect on how the person learned to cope with these pressures, build confidence, or develop healthier self-acceptance. Conclude by explaining the personal growth or lessons the individual gained from this experience.

Your writing will be assessed according to the following criteria.

(Score: 04 for ideas and organization, 3.5 for language and style, and 0.5 for tidiness and legible handwriting).